The Slow Existential Death of a Spaceman

Other Worldly Redemption, Virtual Love, and Real Sanctification

Course Information

Session	Summer 2026
Meeting Times	Mondays and Wednesdays
Dates	June 9 – July 28, 2026
Credits	3

Instructor: Dr. Monty Reynolds mreynolds1@stetson.edu Elizabeth Hall 104 **Office Hours:** By appointment — email to schedule.

Course Description

A primary objective of this course is to teach students how to construct good arguments and how to assess the arguments of others. In this course we use David Chalmers' book *Reality+: Virtual Worlds and the Problems of Philosophy* to look at questions humans have been asking for thousands of years. While the primary focus of the book is one question in particular — "Are we in a simulation?" — we use that question to frame others, it also uses Chalmers' approach to help us understand our own commitments.

This summer section uses **Elite Dangerous** as a philosophical laboratory. It includes three structured experiments completed outside class during assigned windows. Through these experiments, we will test Chalmers' arguments directly: you will navigate permadeath, disable your HUD on atmospheric entry, and manipulate mission stakes to examine whether virtual experience, cognition, and emotion are genuine.

We will not only look at contemporary issues about AI and simulation theory, but will also examine how philosophers of the past posed and attempted to answer these questions. In doing

so we will explore our own commitments including, epistemological (theory of knowledge), metaphysical (the nature of reality), philosophy of mind, and ethics.

Required Texts

- Chalmers, David J. *Reality+: Virtual Worlds and the Problems of Philosophy.* Penguin Books, 2022. Amazon link
- **Elite Dangerous** (PC/console) — free base game available via Epic Games Store or Frontier's launcher. Must be installed before Week 1.

The course will also be supplemented with handouts distributed in class and posted to Canvas.

Course Expectations

- This is a compressed 7-week session. Expect **4 chapters of reading per week** in most weeks. Fall behind and it is very difficult to catch up.
- Come prepared to engage with assigned readings in class, referencing specific passages as prompted by the instructor.
- Bring physical or digital copies of readings to class for annotation and short reflections.
- Submit all assignments via Canvas by the due date.
- Active participation and regular attendance are essential for success.
- Check your Stetson email and Canvas accounts frequently — daily if possible. Technology issues are not accepted as excuses for late or missing work.

Grading

Assignment Breakdown

Assignment	Points
Weekly Reflections (best 5 of 7, 8 pts each)	40 pts
Pilot Assessment Write-Up	20 pts

Assignment	Points
Experiment 1 — Death and Permadeath	40 pts
Experiment 2 — Extended Cognition	40 pts
Experiment 3 — Risk, Respawn, and Moral Emotions	40 pts
Reflective Analysis (80 pts)	80 pts
Essay (40 pts)	40 pts
Attendance	20 pts
Total	**320 pts**

Grading Scale

Grade	Percentage
A	93–100%
A-	90–92%
B+	87–89%
B	83–86%
B-	80–82%
C+	77–79%
C	73–76%

Assignment Rubric

All written assignments (experiments, Reflective Analysis, Essay) are graded on three structural dimensions plus internal criteria.

Structure (applies to all written work)

Layer	What the instructor looks for
Thesis	
Premises	**Excellent:** Every reason clearly stated; sub-arguments provided for controversial claims; basic premises plausibly true.- **Good:** Premises mostly clear; sub-arguments appear for controversial points.- **Needs Improvement:** Premises hard to identify; missing sub-arguments.- **Unacceptable:** No real premises, or premises very likely false.

Layer	What the instructor looks for
Support	- **Excellent:** Premises clearly and strongly support the thesis; argument is logically valid or makes the conclusion very plausible.- **Good:** Premises support the thesis reasonably well.- **Needs Improvement:** Premises only weakly support the thesis; argument is invalid.- **Unacceptable:** Premises do not support the thesis.
Counter-Examples	

Elite Dangerous Experiments

This course uses three structured experiments in Elite Dangerous to test Chalmers' philosophical claims from the inside. Each experiment is a take-home assignment completed during an assigned window and written up using the experiment template on Canvas.

The key principle: experiments and weekly reflections must use Chalmers' language and concepts. The experiments demonstrate the extent to which you understand the material and the arguments. A strong experiment write-up shows: here is what Chalmers (or another philosopher) claims; here is the experiment I ran to test it; here is what I found; here is what that means for the argument.

1. Main claim from Chalmers or someone else.
2. The student's intuition regarding that claim.
3. The experiment student ran to test that claim.
4. The students finding. I.e., whether they've changed their position or not. Why?

Experiment Windows

For full instructions, see the experiment briefings in the Weekly Schedule and on Canvas.

Experiment Grading (40 points each)

Date	Event	Type

Important Dates

Date	Event	Type
Mon June 22	First day of class	
	Pilot Assessment	Experiment
June 30 – July 4	**Fourth of July Break — No Class**	
	Extended Cognition	Experiment
	Death and Permadeath	Experiment
	Risk, Respawn, and Moral Emotions	Experiment
Mon July 28	Last day of class	
Mon July 21	Reflective Analysis due (Canvas)	
Mon July 28	Essay due (Canvas)	

Reading Schedule

Weeklies due every Sunday. Reading by Part — see chapter counts in Notes column. Schedule subject to change — check Canvas regularly.

Elite Dangerous experiment windows are take-home; complete anytime during the listed dates. Bring your experiment log to class the following Monday.

Week	Date(s)	Reading	Notes	Topic
1	Mon June 9 / Wed June 11	Intro + Part One: Chs. 1–3	Course introduction. What is philosophy and why does it matter? The simulation hypothesis as a lens for the whole discipline. Introduction to Elite Dangerous as a philosophical laboratory.	• Handouts (distributed in class) • Chalmers, Introduction: "Adventures in Technophilosophy" • Chalmers, Ch. 1: "Is This the Real Life?" **Wed June 11:** • Chalmers, Ch. 2: "What Is the Simulation Hypothesis?" • Chalmers, Ch. 3: "Do We Know Things?"

Week	Date(s)	Reading	Notes	Topic
2	Mon June 16 / Wed June 18	Part Two: Chs. 4–7	Having established the epistemic problem, we now ask the metaphysical question: what is reality? Is the universe made of matter, information, or something else? _4 chapters; Write-Up assigned Wed, weekly	**Mon June 16:** • Chalmers, Ch. 4: "Can We Prove There Is an External World?" • Chalmers, Ch. 5: "Is It Likely That We're in a Simulation?" (Bostrom and Moravec) **Wed June 18:** • Chalmers, Ch. 6: "What Is Reality?" • Chalmers, Ch. 7: "Is God a Hacker in the Next Universe Up?"
3	Mon June 23 / Wed June 25	Part Three A: Chs. 8–11	What is reality? Is the mind a part of reality? — and whether a mind can exist, think, and be conscious inside a virtual world. _4 chapters; **Exp. 1 window June 20–26**	**Mon July 7:** *(Pilot Assessment Write-Up due today)* • Chalmers, Ch. 12: "Does Augmented Reality Lead to Alternative Facts?" • Chalmers, Ch. 13: "Can We Avoid Being Deceived by Deepfakes?" **Wed July 9:** • Chalmers, Ch. 14: "How Do Mind and Body Interact in a Virtual World?" • Chalmers, Ch. 15: "Can There Be Consciousness in a Digital World?"
—	June 30 – July 4	*Fourth of July Break*	No class	
4	Mon July 7 / Wed July 9	Part Three B: Chs. 12–15	If we can live, think, and be conscious in a virtual world, does that world have moral significance? Can we live a good virtual life? _4 chapters; Write-Up due Mon	
5	Mon July 14 / Wed July 16	Part Four A: Chs. 16–19	4 chapters; **Exp. 2 window July 11–17**	**Mon July 14:** • Chalmers, Ch. 16: "Does Augmented Reality Extend the Mind?" **Wed July 16:** • Chalmers, Ch. 17: "Can You Lead a Good Life in a Virtual World?" • Chalmers, Ch. 18: "Do Simulated Lives Matter?" • Chalmers, Ch. 19: "How Should We Build a Virtual Society?" *(begin)*

Week	Date(s)	Reading	Notes	Topic
6	Mon July 21 / Wed July 23	Part Four B: Chs. 20–22	3 chapters; RA due Mon; **Exp. 3 window July 25–31**	
7	Mon July 28	Part Five: Chs. 23–24 + Review	2 chapters; Essay due; last day	

Academic Policies

Academic Integrity

All work you submit must be your own. Sign all submissions: *"Pledged, [your name]."* Any contribution from others must be clearly acknowledged. Academic dishonesty — including plagiarism, unauthorized collaboration, and misrepresentation — will be referred to the Academic Honor Council and may result in suspension or dismissal. Honor code: http://www.stetson.edu/honorsystem/

Late Work

All assignments must be submitted on time. Late work is docked a half-letter grade per day unless an extension is approved before the due date. In a 7-week session, late work compounds rapidly.

Accommodations

If you anticipate barriers related to the format or requirements of this course, please meet with me early in the session. If disability-related accommodations are necessary, register with the Academic Success Center:

- Phone: 386-822-7127
- Website: www.stetson.edu/asc

Free tutoring is also available through the ASC: www.stetson.edu/asc/tutoring/php

Writing Center

Located on the second floor of the library. One or two visits can make a significant difference in the quality of your written work.

Food Insecurity

The Hatters Helping Hatters Food Pantry is available to all Stetson students, staff, and faculty — free and no questions asked. Location: Carlton Union Building (CUB 278), open 24 hours.

Counseling Center

Phone: 386-822-8900 | Location: Griffith Hall Hours: Weekdays 8:00 AM–4:30 PM After-hours emergencies: Public Safety 386-822-7300 (ask for the on-call counselor). Crisis line: 386-822-8740 — Option 1 for thoughts of harm; Option 9 for all other mental health needs. Medical emergencies: call 911.

Recording Policy

Any recordings of class (audio, video, or otherwise) may only be used for personal academic purposes and may not be shared without the professor's written consent. Violation will be reported to the Office of Community Standards.